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# Do people change the way they speak when they talk to you? Chinese and Spanish-speakers' perceptions of and attitudes towards foreigner talk

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**Abstract** – The study analyzes the perceptions and attitudes towards foreigner talk (FT), a speech register used when communicating with perceived foreigners. The study, unique in its focus on non-native English speakers, specifically those with Spanish or Chinese as their first language, recruited 64 participants through snowball sampling. The participants, native speakers of either Spanish or Chinese, all learned English after the age of 7. Through an online survey covering language background, attitudes toward native English speakers, experiences with and opinions of FT, and personal language ideologies, the study revealed significant differences between Chinese and Spanish speakers in their perceptions of FT. Chinese speakers displayed more favorable attitudes towards FT, feeling closer to a native speaker using FT compared to Spanish speakers. Conversely, Chinese participants experienced more social distance when interacting with someone in their own language compared to Spanish participants. These findings are true despite there being no significant difference in the amount of FT that Chinese-speaking and Spanish-speaking participants reported receiving. Correlations revealed that longer residence in the United States and lower self-reported accent correlated with a decreased amount of FT received. Participants with lower English proficiency found FT more helpful in both language groups. Additionally, individuals with stronger self-reported accents demonstrated lower prejudice towards others with accents. These findings contribute to understanding the impact of FT on non-native speakers and emphasize the importance of raising awareness among native speakers employing FT

*Keywords:* foreigner talk, non-native speakers, language perceptions, accents, belonging

Foreigner talk (FT) refers to a simplified version of language employed by native speakers when addressing non-native speakers. Many studies have explored native English speakers' attitudes towards foreign speakers in the United States, as well as their corresponding beliefs about them. Past authors inquired whether individuals make an effort to comprehend foreigners or merely dismiss them (Derwing et al., 2010). Furthermore, papers assessed whether individuals alter their speech patterns and personas when interacting with non-native speakers (Ferguson, 1975). These investigations were critical in determining the characteristics of and reasoning behind FT.

The current study approaches the subject from a different perspective by focusing on the foreign speaker's point of view, analyzing non-native speakers' perceptions and beliefs surrounding FT. The paper examines reception of FT, specifically asking what demographic groups are more likely to encounter it, and whether attitudes toward FT differ across these groups. Additionally, the study aims to determine correlations between FT and feelings of belongingness in American culture, language ideologies, and social distance between foreigners and non-foreigners.

## Features of, and Evidence for, FT

In 1971, Charles Ferguson coined the term foreigner talk as speech "used by speakers of a language to outsiders who are felt to have very limited command of the language or no knowledge of it at all." Ferguson suggested that many languages have particular features of pronunciation, grammar, and lexicon which are used when talking with foreigners. For example, a speaker of Spanish who wants to communicate with a foreigner will use the infinitive form of the verb rather than the correct conjugation (Ferguson, 1971). A few years later in 1975, Ferguson provided native students with ten sentences and asked them to write "equivalent phrases" directed towards a foreigner. All but two of the 36 students provided "foreigner talk sentences," suggesting

substantial agreement in basic features of FT and confirming that it is a widespread phenomenon (Ferguson, 1975). However, this work did not examine how people actually talk in real-life conversation.

To test the direct use of FT, Lugrin and colleagues (2018) assessed whether people tend to adapt to their conversational partners in a mixed-cultural setting with a native and non-native speaker. The results revealed that participants (all native speakers of English) behaved significantly differently towards an English speaker with a foreign accent, reducing the number of words, speed of speech, time of interactions, and non-verbal cues. Lugrin called this phenomenon AFC: adapted, foreigner-directed communication (Lugrin et al., 2018).

Similarly, the sociolinguistic framework CAT (Communication Accommodation Theory) states that native speakers modify their speech to meet the communicative needs of non-native speakers (Beebe & Giles, 1984). Foreigner-directed speech (FDS) is a specific form of CAT characterized by general vowel hyperarticulation and a decrease in speech rates, intended to assist second-language learners (Uther et al., 2007). Another study used imaginal situations to find that FDS is also associated with exaggerated pitch range (Papoušek & Hwang, 1991).

Evelyn Hatch (1983) proposed three concrete characteristics of FT: regression, matching, and negotiation. With regression, native speakers regress back through stages of their own language development, until they find an appropriate level to match the listener. With matching, native speakers attempt to understand the state of the speaker and imitate their observations. Finally, with negotiation, native speakers simplify and clarify their speech according to feedback they obtain from the listeners they are communicating with.

**Functions of, and Views on, FT**

A double message exists regarding FT: FT may be perceived as helpful to non-native speakers, and/or it may be perceived as patronizing (Bobb et al., 2019). These contrasting opinions suggest that FT still has an inconclusive role in aiding second-language acquisition (Dela Rosa & Arguelles, 2016). The perception of FT may vary among individuals on the giving and receiving ends, and even across different cultural contexts.

For the argument of FT as a helpful phenomenon, many believe that native speakers adjust their speech to optimize comprehension and lighten the burden of non-native speakers. There are three ways that native speakers do this: omission, expansion, and replacement (Ferguson, 1975). In this regard, non-native speakers mean well to modify their speech to meet the needs of foreigners and assist them (Bobb et al., 2019). For example, in a questionnaire sent to native English speakers, four fifths of respondents claimed that FT fostered communication, suggested respect and consideration for non-native speakers, and avoided conflict (Drljača Margić, 2017). Ensuring a smooth exchange of information, FT can be viewed as facilitative and positive.

On the other hand, using FT may imply the offensive idea that native speakers are superior to non-native speakers. Foreigners often receive more FT than they believe is necessary, suggesting their linguistic inadequacy (Bobb et al., 2019). This form of speech is seen as condescending, controlling, and dismissive, making foreigners feel incompetent (Zuengler, 1991). From the native speaker's point of view, Ferguson (1975) found that native English students had an overall negative attitude and disapproval towards the use of FT (Ferguson, 1975). A similar study asking native speakers to "transform sentences for foreigners" found that adults felt uncomfortable and sometimes even refused to take part in the research, supporting that native speakers as well hold negative views towards FT (Fedorova, 2018).

Another reason for negative sentiments towards FT is because it shares some features with Baby Talk, a form of language which is regarded by a speech community as being primarily appropriate for talking to young children, and not the normal adult use of language (Ferguson, 1964). FT is similar to baby talk in many ways; both are characterized by frequent pauses, a limited vocabulary, and brevity (Freed, 1981). Additionally, both speech registers include the repetition of words and imitation of foreign speakers (Freed, 1981).

**FT Across Diverse Language Communities**

Although prior work has looked at FT as a general phenomenon, there is reason to hypothesize that how FT is used and perceived may vary depending on the language and/or ethnic group of the foreign speaker. There are many stereotypes about people based on how they speak; conversely, there exist stereotypes about how people speak based on their identity. Developmental psychologist Katherine Kinzler suggested that someone's language and accent provides a tremendous amount of social information to a listener (Kinzler, 2021). Studying children as young as five years old, Kinzler found that children think about language as a marker for national identity, allowing it to be a vehicle for social grouping (Kinzler, 2013, 2021). As time has progressed, more studies have focused on examining FT towards specific accent groups to see if there is variation within attitudes depending on the foreign individual's race/ethnicity.

The focus of the present study is on English speakers whose first language was Chinese or Spanish, and who did not learn English until later in childhood (age seven or older). The inclusion of Spanish speakers in the study is particularly significant because of the prevalence of Latinos in the U.S. – 18.9% of the U.S. population identifies as Hispanic and/or Latino, many of whom are Spanish speakers (Office of Minority Health, 2023). Native Chinese speakers were included due to previous research indicating negative stereotyping towards Asians in the United States. The rationale for this comparison between languages is that many native English speakers in the U.S. have been found to hold implicit stereotypes that may differ between Chinese and Spanish speakers. Although FT is related to the accents of non-native speakers, it is also hypothesized to intersect with biases associated with beliefs, associations, and stereotypes about people of different national/ethnic/linguistic groups.

### *Asian FT as a Stereotype*

Some studies show that if a person is a member of an Asian group, then they are assumed to have an accent (even when they don't), or are judged harder to understand (even when controlling for speech sample). When controlling for speech presented to participants, research suggests stereotypes about language intelligibility. In Rubin (1992), students heard speech associated with a picture of an Asian face and reported hearing a "heavy accent" that actually did not exist (Rubin, 1992). Another study was conducted with White and South Asian faces to determine if race impacted native English-listeners' perceptions of how another person speaks English. Results revealed that accentedness judgments increased for all varieties when speech was paired with South Asian faces (Kutlu et al., 2022). These cases suggest that upon hearing someone's accent, a listener makes predetermined judgments about how they *will* speak, judgments that are not based on how the person *actually* speaks.

More research, although not directly controlling for speech presented to participants, may also reflect language stereotypes. A study focused on Vietnamese-accented speakers found that native English participants required more attention when listening to a Vietnamese-accented speaker (Hosoda et al., 2007). Similarly, when researchers asked listeners of various backgrounds (Indian, Chinese, Korean, American) to rate the intelligibility of Chinese graduate students, all listeners rated English L1 students (students whose first language is English) as more intelligible than Mandarin L1 students. The only exception was Mandarin L1 listeners, who found the two groups equally intelligible (Hardman, 2010).

Furthermore, research shows that if a person speaks with an accent from an Asian language, then people have certain stereotypes about what they are like. In an experiment directly testing how much people believe non-native speakers, participants judged trivia statements such as "ants don't sleep" as less true when stated by Korean-accented speakers versus native English speakers (Lev-Ari & Keysar, 2010). Relative to standard American-accented English speakers, Vietnamese-accented English speakers were perceived as poorer communicators who were less potent, less threatening, and more concerned about others (Hosoda et al., 2007). Native-English speakers also perceived Asians to be "highly competitive and technologically-skilled" (Carlson & McHenry, 2006). Another study found that Chinese-accented speakers were deemed less attractive than standard American-accented speakers in the context of a college classroom (Cargile, 1997). These cognitive reactions to Asian-accented English speakers suggest a set of stereotypes regarding characteristics deriving from the accent of someone whose first language was an Asian language.

Previous papers suggest that not all Asian subgroups perceive FT the same. A 2010 study reported that Malaysian students highly valued their accented English, while Japanese and Koreans disapproved of their own varieties of English and indicated their preference for native English pronunciation. Additionally, in the eyes of native speakers, different East Asian ethnicities such as Vietnamese and Mandarin are seen differently, even though they are both Asian – Vietnamese speakers were rated as more foreign by native speakers (Cargile et al., 2010). Due to this finding, rather than consolidating all Asian languages into a single category, the analysis centers on a single language. Given that Chinese is the most widely spoken East Asian language, this study includes only Chinese language participants as an exemplar for the East Asian group.

### *Spanish FT as a Stereotype*

Stereotypes about Latinos in the U.S. are hypothesized to affect how people speak to someone whose first language is Spanish. Individuals speaking English with a Spanish accent are more likely to be judged negatively than someone speaking with an American-English accent: Spanish-accented speakers were rated as less competent, less knowledgeable, and of lower status compared to native English speakers (Cargile et al., 2010; Nelson et al., 2016). Spanish-accented individuals were also rated as less socially attractive than their American-English accented counterparts

(Montgomery & Zhang, 2018). Other perceptions exist surrounding Spanish-accented speakers, such as the conception that they are "poor, efficient, and hardworking" (DuBois, 2017).

In addition to facing character judgments, Latinos in the United States have encountered discrimination linked to their accents, notably in regards to employment opportunities. An empirical study revealed that, in the context of applying for a software engineering position, a hypothetical applicant with a Mexican-Spanish accent was disadvantaged compared to someone with a standard American-English accent (Hosoda et al., 2012). The individual with the Mexican-Spanish accent received lower ratings in terms of job suitability and was perceived as less likely to be promoted to a managerial role (Hosoda et al., 2012). In interviews with foreigners, Spanish-accented speakers said that discrimination took place "once in a while," and more frequently at work or school, at government offices or in department stores (Korzenny and Schiff, 1987). We hypothesized that accent-based discrimination affects how people treat Latino individuals, and also how these people perceive themselves; microaggressions can be particularly cognitively and emotionally taxing for members of stigmatized groups (Sue et al., 2007).

### *Comparisons of Chinese and Spanish FT*

Prior literature indicates that native English speakers perceive Spanish speakers as "less foreign" than Chinese speakers, leading to a comparison between the two groups. In a study asking Americans to rank "foreignness" of different languages, Asians were rated as "the most foreign," while Latinos were only rated as "moderately foreign" (Cargile et al., 2010). Another experiment about perceived degrees of accentedness found that native Spanish speakers were judged not to have any accent when speaking English, whereas native Chinese subjects were judged as having a measurable accent – however, these studies did not control for age of English acquisition (AOL), and therefore effects may be due to AOL rather than the speaker's native language (Flege & Fletcher, 1992). When students listened to verbal recordings paired with an American, Hispanic, or Asian phenotype (face), the students preferred to interact with the Hispanic phenotype when paired with a native English accent (McCrocklin et al., 2018). However, this may have been because 93% of participants in the study were Hispanic, and felt that they related better to a person from a similar background (McCrocklin et al., 2018).

To this date, only one major experiment, conducted by Podberesky (1990), has compared language discrimination directly between Chinese and Spanish speakers – but this study also clumped Chinese into a category called "Oriental" which also included Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese, etc. Podberesky found that there was no difference in perception of traits amongst the groups. It is important to note, however, that the study group consisted of 19.5-year-old (mean age) college students living in a diverse university town with a high rate of non-native speakers of English, potentially skewing the results. Furthermore, the paper did not exclusively center on FT (Podberesky et al., 1990).

## Rationale for Current Study

In light of recent research identifying racial/ethnic differences in how FT is perceived, the current study analyzes non-native speakers' perceptions of FT, with a specific focus on individuals whose first language is either Chinese or Spanish. The primary investigation analyzes non-native English speakers' experiences with FT, their attitudes toward FT, and whether these differ as a function of their linguistic/ethnic background.

This thesis adopts a novel perspective because it focuses on FT between these two groups specifically. Very few past studies have compared Chinese and Spanish speakers, and from these, none have directly analyzed FT (Podberesky et al., 1990). Amongst other papers that *did* study FT, none solely focused on a comparison between Chinese and Spanish speakers. Additionally, most past research predominantly explored how FT was used by native speakers, rather than the perception by non-native recipients. The current study will be the first of its kind, integrating a broader examination of language perceptions among Chinese and Spanish speakers with a specific emphasis on the phenomenon of FT.

## Research Questions

Based on background knowledge and literature, three research questions were generated about non-native speakers' perceptions of FT, outlined below:

**Q1:** Do Chinese and Spanish-speaking participants receive different amounts of FT? We hypothesize that Chinese speakers will receive more FT than Spanish speakers due to biases associated with beliefs/associations/stereotypes about people of Asian descent.

**Q2:** Do language beliefs and ideologies differ between Chinese versus Spanish speakers? One possibility is that Chinese speakers will have more negative perceptions of FT, feel less close to English speakers, and feel like they belong less in the U.S. due to receiving more FT than they believe is necessary. This would be consistent with prior findings that Chinese speakers are assumed to be less skilled in English than they actually are. Another possibility is that Chinese

speakers will have more positive perceptions of FT, feel more close to English speakers, and feel like they belong more in the U.S. due to having lower English abilities and finding FT helpful in aiding comprehension. This would be consistent with the greater linguistic relatedness and similarity between English and Spanish than between English and Chinese, thus potentially resulting in greater challenges with the English language.

**Q3:** Do we find language background factors correlated with FT? We hypothesize that age of English acquisition, length of stay in the U.S., English ability, and accent in English will correlate with frequency of receiving FT, attitudes toward FT, favor towards monolingualism, and accent prejudice.

To test the three research questions, an online survey was designed and distributed to U.S. adults both locally and nationwide. Participants were required to be non-native English speakers with either Chinese or Spanish as their first/native language.

## Method

All study procedures were approved by the University of Michigan Institutional Review Board (HUM00140836). Data collection occurred in November 2023. A pilot study about non-native speakers' perceptions of FT was conducted in 2018 by Danielle Labotka. The current study focused on the differences in the frequency and attitudes of FT between non-native Spanish and Chinese speakers.

### Power Analysis

Power was calculated with G*Power using an effect size of $d = 0.80$ to indicate high practical significance of the research outcome. Power with this sample size is 80%, as this is a generally-accepted power level to avoid Type II errors. The alpha level is 0.05. According to these criteria, 26 participants were needed in each group. To account for attrition and drop-criteria, the study aimed to have a sample size of 30 participants in each category.

### Participants

Recruitment was via snowball sampling, a method in which initial participants recruit additional participants from their network, creating a "snowball" effect. Snowball sampling was advantageous in this situation due to the target population being difficult to reach through traditional sampling methods. The process began with the initial identification of a few participant groups (e.g., student groups on campus), then relied on referrals to others. To aim for diversity within the sample, the survey was sent to student organizations, faculty departments, and participants from outside the Ann Arbor area. Participants completed the survey hosted by Qualtrics, an online platform designed for creating and distributing surveys. All participation was volunteer-based, therefore participants were not compensated for their time. Only residents of the US were allowed to participate. The survey took an average of 10 minutes to complete.

The final sample consisted of 41 Spanish speakers and 23 Chinese speakers. The sample of Spanish speakers is above the goal of 26 determined by the power analysis, but the sample of Chinese speakers is lower. No information was gathered on participant gender. Participants were on average 34 years old, with the youngest participant being 18 and oldest 65 years old ($M = 33.58$, $SD = 13.07$). The sample size learned English at an average age of 11 ($M = 11.11$, $SD = 4.92$) and has been living in the U.S. for around 11 years ($M = 11.36$, $SD = 9.99$). Most of the sample was highly educated, with 56.25% percent receiving a master's degree or higher. Spanish-speaking participants were from 12 different countries, and Chinese participants were from 2 different countries (see Appendix A).

Because the study required participants to be non-native English speakers, any participants who reported English as their first language ($n = 3$) or learned English before the age of 7 ($n = 4$) were removed from the survey. Additionally, participants who were not native Chinese or Spanish speakers were kicked out in prescreening. Once the survey began, to ensure that only participants who were engaged with the task were included in the final sample, two attention checks were presented. As an example, one attention check stated "This is an attention check. Copy the following sentence into the box below: Grass is green and the sky is blue." Participants who did not pass both attention checks were dropped from the sample ($n = 3$). Participants who did not respond to all questions in the survey were dropped ($n = 16$), unless they completely answered the first block of questions, in which case they were included in statistical analyses that pertained to the first block only ($n = 8$). Finally, one bot question was placed at the end of the survey to ensure participants were human, and participants who failed to answer the question were also dropped ($n = 18$).

### Materials and Procedure

Each participant filled out a questionnaire that measured their experiences with and opinions of FT, and how FT related to different ideological beliefs. The questionnaire was based on prior research conducted by Danielle Labotka and Susan Gelman (unpublished). Since recruitment was completed via snowball sampling, we assumed that the majority of participants would fit the study's criteria. Nevertheless, before the questions began,

participants were presented with two pre-screening questions: one to ensure they were native Chinese or Spanish speakers, and another to confirm that they learned English after the age of 7. If participants did not pass these pre-screening questions, they were directed to an exit screen and thanked for their time. Participants who passed the screener questions were next asked to provide demographic information, including their age, race/ethnicity, education level, country of origin, and length of residence in the U.S.

Next, participants reported information about their language experience/background, including their native language and age of English acquisition. They rated dimensions of their English ability on a 7-point scale, including how comfortable they are speaking English (1 = Not comfortable at all, 7 = Very comfortable), how fluent they are in English (1 = Not fluent at all, 7 = Very fluent), and how grammatically correct their English is (1 = Not grammatically correct at all, 7 = Completely grammatically correct). Additionally, participants rated how accented their English is on a 7-point scale (1 = Not accented at all, 7 = Very accented). A composite subscale was created combining all four variables, but the alpha did not reach reliability ($\alpha = .66$). Consequently, "accentedness" was dropped, and the final subscale consisted of "comfortability," "fluency," and "grammatically correct" – this composite was called *English ability* ($\alpha = .76$).

After the demographics information, participants provided information about their personal attitudes and experiences talking to native English speakers. First, participants rated how much they felt they belonged in the U.S. on a 7-point scale (1 = Don't belong at all, 7 = Completely belong). They then reported how close they felt to a person when they talked to them in both their native language and in English (1 = Not close at all, 7 = Very close). In the next question, participants were asked how much native speakers changed their speech when talking to them versus a native speaker on a 7-point scale (1 = No change, 7 = Change a lot). Finally, in an open-ended question, they were asked what kinds of changes they notice native speakers make in their speech when talking to them.

Then, the study provided an explanation of FT as "the changes in speech native speakers may make when talking to non-native speakers – characterized by slow, loud, over-enunciated, and simplified speech." Participants were asked an open-ended question about what changes native speakers make to their language when using FT, then asked to indicate whether they had ever received FT (Yes, Maybe, No). In a check-the-box question, participants selected which aspect(s) of FT they received (slow speech, loud speech, over-enunciated speech, simplified speech, other).

Participants then provided information regarding their experiences with FT. First, they indicated on a 7-point scale how often they receive FT (1 = Never, 7 = All the time). Second, they answered how close they felt to a person when they talked to them in FT (1 = Not close at all, 7 = Very close). Then, they rated on a 7-point scale how helpful they found FT (1 = Not helpful at all, 7 = Very helpful) and how offended they were by FT (1 = Not offended at all, 7 = Very offended). They also gave social ratings of a person who uses FT, including how much they like them (1 = Not like them at all, 7 = Like them a lot) and the positive/negative impact of using FT on their opinion of a person (1 = No positive/negative impact, 7 = Very positive/negative impact). In the last scale regarding FT, participants rated how much they felt they belonged in the U.S. when they received FT on a 7-point scale (1 = Don't belong at all, 7 = Completely belong). The block ended with a free-response question asking what a person using FT thinks about them.

The final portion of the survey was dedicated to measures of participants' American language ideologies. In a 2018 unpublished study, Danielle Labotka adapted scales of language ideologies to measure participants' acceptance of monolingualism (Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011) and accent prejudice (Ura et al, 2015). Participants received 42 statements about language – 21 about monolingualism, 21 about accent prejudice – and rated how much they agreed with each statement on a 6-point scale (1 = Strongly disagree, 6 = Strongly agree). All of the included measures have been found to be valid and reliable in previous research (see Appendix B).

The overall interest of the survey was in attitudes, experiences, and evaluations of FT. Attitudes and experiences were measured with the first section of questions, while evaluations were measured with the second section of pre-scaled questions.

**Statistical Analysis**

The study used two different statistical tests to analyze the data: t-test and correlation. The first analysis examined the rates of receiving FT, attempting to answer the question "Is there a difference between the amount of FT received between Chinese speakers and Spanish speakers?" The question was posed in order to determine if factors such as racial biases came into play. T-tests were conducted to compare the two different non-native language groups on their frequency of receiving FT (see Appendix C). In a similar analysis, multiple paired-sample t-tests were conducted to investigate differences in how Chinese and Spanish participants evaluated FT (see Appendix C). A final analysis consisted of sets of

bivariate correlations (using Pearson's correlation coefficient) to analyze what factors relate to non-native speakers receiving FT (see Appendix D). All analyses were implemented in SPSS 29.

## Results

### How do Chinese versus Spanish Speakers Compare in Measures Unrelated to FT?

Before evaluating the proposed research questions, it is important to examine language background and demographic information among the participants to identify similarities and distinctions. The Chinese participants' English ability (a subscale created by combining three questions, α = .76) was lower than the average Spanish speakers' English ability (*Ms* (*SDs*) = 5.05 (1.0) vs. 5.90 (0.98), respectively), $t(62) = 3.26$, $p = .002$. More specifically, the Chinese speakers reported being less comfortable speaking English (*Ms* (*SDs*) = 5.48 (1.50) vs. 6.20 (1.31), $p = .05$), less fluent in English (*Ms* (*SDs*) = 5.26 (1.29) vs. 6.22 (1.01), $p = .002$), and less grammatically-correct when speaking English (*Ms* (*SDs*) = 4.43 (0.99) vs. 5.29 (1.31), $p = .009$) when compared to Spanish speakers. There was no significant difference in self-reported accent between Chinese-speaking ($M = 4.04$, $SD = 1.55$) and Spanish-speaking participants ($M = 4.84$, $SD = 1.68$), $t(62) = 1.88$, $p = .07$. Additionally, there was no difference in length of stay in the United States between Chinese-speaking ($M = 9.17$, $SD = 7.41$) and Spanish-speaking participants ($M = 12.66$, $SD = 11.07$), $t(62) = -1.34$, $p = .07$, even though Spanish speakers had lived in the U.S. for an on-average greater time. Finally, there was no significant difference in age of English acquisition between Chinese-speaking ($M = 10.0$, $SD = 3.12$) and Spanish-speaking participants ($M = 11.78$, $SD = 5.58$), $t(62) = -1.41$, $p = .05$. In terms of education, 41% percent of Spanish speakers received higher than a bachelor's degree, while 83% percent of Chinese speakers did ($X2$ (1, $N = 64$) = 10.14, $p = .001$). The two groups did not differ in their attitudes towards monolingualism ($M_{\text{Chinese}} = 2.94$, $SD = 0.55$; $M_{\text{Spanish}} = 2.65$, $SD = 0.61$; $t(54) = -1.79$, $p = .08$) or prejudice against accents ($M_{\text{Chinese}} = 2.06$, $SD = 0.64$; $M_{\text{Spanish}} = 1.82$, $SD = 0.53$; $t(54) = -1.52$, $p = .14$).

### How do Chinese versus Spanish Speakers Compare in Frequency of Receiving FT?

Participants were asked if they ever received FT, given the choices of yes, no, or maybe. Only 3% said 'no'; 64% said 'yes' and 33% said 'maybe.' Research Question 1 asked whether we will find a difference in receiving FT between Chinese and Spanish-speaking participants. The hypothesis was not supported according to two *t*-tests. When calculating the difference in ever receiving FT (Yes = 2, Maybe = 1, No = 0), there was no significant difference between Spanish speakers ($M = 1.61$, $SD = 0.59$) and Chinese speakers ($M = 1.61$, $SD = 0.50$), $t(61) = 0.007$, $p = .99$. Similarly, when calculating the difference in frequency of receiving FT (on a scale of 1-7), there was also no significant difference between Spanish speakers ($M = 3.00$, $SD = 1.39$) and Chinese speakers ($M = 2.83$, $SD = 0.98$), $t(62) = 0.53$, $p = .60$.

### How do Chinese versus Spanish Speakers Evaluate FT?

Research Question 2 asked whether we find a difference in language beliefs and ideologies among Chinese versus Spanish speakers. This hypothesis was partially supported.

A subscale for *attitudes towards FT* combined seven questions, all relating to non-native speakers' attitudes towards receiving FT, with a higher number representing a more favorable opinion of FT (α = .91). Chinese participants ($M = 4.14$, $SD = 1.21$) have more favorable attitudes towards receiving FT than Spanish speakers ($M = 3.18$, $SD = 1.61$), $t(62) = -2.48$, $p = .02$.

In terms of *social distance when receiving FT*, Chinese participants ($M = 3.43$, $SD = 1.47$) felt more close to a person speaking to them in FT than Spanish speakers ($M = 2.39$, $SD = 1.71$), $t(62) = -2.46$, $p = .01$. An additional analysis found that Chinese participants ($M = 5.43$, $SD = 1.53$) have a significantly lower average than Spanish participants ($M = 6.34$, $SD = 0.88$) in terms of *closeness to a person when speaking native language*, meaning that Chinese participants do not feel as close to others speaking Chinese as Spanish speakers feel close to others speaking Spanish, $t(62) = 3.01$, $p = .004$.

There was no significant effect for *feelings of belongingness* in the U.S., $t(62) = 1.11$, $p = .27$, despite Chinese speakers ($M = 4.07$, $SD = 1.78$) attaining higher scores than Spanish speakers ($M = 3.57$, $SD = 1.72$). Additionally, there was no significant difference in *feelings of belonging in the U.S. when receiving FT* between Chinese speakers ($M = 2.78$, $SD = 1.68$) and Spanish speakers ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 1.94$), $t(62) = -2.07$, $p = .84$.

### What Factors Correlate with Non-Native Speakers Receiving FT?

The final Research Question asked whether we find language background factors correlated with FT. Specifically, Q3 hypothesized that age of English acquisition, length of stay in the U.S., English ability, and self-reported accent in English would correlate with frequency of receiving FT, positive attitudes toward FT, favorable attitudes towards monolingualism, and accent prejudice. The hypothesis was partially supported by the results.

As predicted, *frequency of receiving FT* was negatively correlated with English ability ($r$ = -.36), meaning those with higher self-reported English ability received less FT. Also as predicted, frequency of receiving FT was negatively correlated with length of stay in the U.S. ($r$ = -.36), suggesting that participants who have lived in the U.S. longer received less FT. Frequency of receiving FT was positively correlated with accent in English ($r$ = .32), meaning the greater one's self-reported accent, the more FT they receive. There was no significant correlation between frequency of receiving FT and age of English acquisition ($r$ = .11).

*Positive attitudes toward FT* were negatively correlated with English ability ($r$ = -.57), suggesting those with higher self-reported English ability had more negative attitudes towards FT. There was no significant correlation between attitudes toward FT and accent in English ($r$ = .20), age of English acquisition ($r$ = .23), or length of stay in the U.S. (.02).

*Favorable attitudes towards monolingualism* were not significantly correlated with English ability ($r$ = -.12), accent in English ($r$ = .07), age of English acquisition ($r$ = -.1), or length of stay in the U.S. ($r$ = .09). However, favorable attitudes towards monolingualism were positively correlated with positive attitudes toward FT ($r$ = .34), meaning participants who favored the use of one language felt more positively about using FT.

Finally, *accent prejudice* was negatively correlated with respondents' accent in English ($r$ = -.31), suggesting that those with a greater self-reported accent had less prejudice towards different accents. Accent prejudice was not significantly correlated with English ability ($r$ = -.10), age of English acquisition ($r$ = -.29), or length of stay in the U.S. ($r$ = -.28). Accent prejudice was, however, highly positively correlated with favorable attitudes towards monolingualism ($r$ = .53), meaning participants with greater prejudice against accents also possessed monolinguistic attitudes, favoring the use of one language.

### Open-Ended Responses

Open-ended responses were collected from participants to assess their thoughts on and views of FT from a non-native English speaker's perspective. First, participants were asked, "What do you think are some changes native speakers make to their language when using FT?" Most responses mentioned that native speakers use simplified speech, talk slower, and use less complicated language. One Chinese-speaking participant reported that native speakers are "trying to paraphrase certain terms or sentences and try to add explanations for cultural-specific or generation-specific terms used in the U.S." Similarly, a Spanish-speaking participant wrote that native speakers use "intonation of certain words that 'sounds like a teacher.'" Some participants also thought native speakers' use of FT reflected negative attitudes, for example, "They think we are newcomers here and don't understand English... or they think someone with an accent is stupid. I've had to call it out exactly like that."

Participants were also asked, "What do you think a person using FT thinks about you?" Responses were coded as negative, positive, both, neither, or no response. The majority of participants (55%) reported negative responses, such as, "They think that because I'm foreign I'm stupid." In contrast, 19% of participants reported positive responses, such as, "They are considerate and willing to include me into their conversation." Finally, 9% of responses reported both negative and positive responses, depending on the person or situation. For example, one Chinese-speaking participant wrote, "Some of them are nice and try to have an inclusive, friendly conversation with me. However, there are also people who inherently think I don't belong to the same community they belong to and try to separate or 'distinct' them from me using FT." A Spanish-speaking participant likewise wrote, "I think it depends on the situation, sometimes we might need to simplify our speech. However, that person may think that I'm not smart enough to follow the pace of the conversation." The remaining 5% of participants fit into the 'neither' category, and 12% of participants did not respond to the question. Open-ended questions highlighted the double-message surrounding the use of FT.

## Discussion

The phenomenon of FT has a daily impact on millions of Spanish and Chinese speakers in the United States. The current study is the first to examine FT from the perspective of the non-native speaker, involving a direct comparison of Chinese and Spanish speakers. The study found that the majority of participants (64%) reported receiving FT at least once in their lives, suggesting the concept is still apparent in the modern day. The study explored variations in FT across different language groups, attempting to understand perceptions and attitudes towards FT.

The primary finding of the study was that Chinese-speaking and Spanish-speaking participants had different perceptions of FT; Chinese-speaking participants exhibited significantly more favorable attitudes toward receiving FT and felt closer to a native speaker talking to them using FT compared to Spanish speakers. Conversely, Chinese participants felt more social distance to someone speaking their own language when compared to Spanish participants. This finding was true despite there being no significant difference in the

amount of FT received between Chinese-speaking and Spanish-speaking participants. Across both groups, the longer a participant had lived in the United States and the less of an accent they reported having, the less likely they were to receive FT. Participants with lower English ability found receiving FT more helpful among both language groups. Additionally, people with greater accents had less prejudice towards others with accents.

Frequency of receiving FT between Chinese and Spanish participants failed to support the original hypothesis and literature. The hypothesis presumed that, given the distinct stereotypes associated with Chinese and Spanish speakers in terms of language and personality, Chinese participants would encounter more instances of FT (Cargile et al., 2010; Flege & Fletcher, 1992; McCrocklin et al., 2018). However, the present study indicates that the participants' native language or origin did not significantly influence the amount of FT they receive; why this is the case will require more research. One possibility is that what matters more is the native-speaker's perception of the participant as "foreign," emphasizing the perceived difference and the need for an altered communication approach. Volker Hinnenkamp called this idea the generalized foreigner, explaining that non-native people are categorized and generalized as being "alien" (Hinnenkamp, 1987). Similarly, a 2013 study examining Asians and Latinos found that 91% of participants reported having experienced national origin identity neglect, a phenomenon when people treat members of distinct social groups as interchangeable parts of a broader category (Flores & Huo, 2013). Many native English speakers may simply see both Chinese and Spanish participants as "non-native," and chose to communicate with them both using FT.

Importantly, although the frequency of receiving FT may be comparable between both groups, the perceptions of FT differed among participants. The study revealed that Chinese participants found FT more helpful and felt closer to someone using FT with them. Given that Chinese participants in the study reported having lower levels of English ability, it is perhaps not surprising that Chinese-speakers would have more positive perceptions of someone using a form of speech with them that may be easier to process. One paper suggested that using FT "may serve to facilitate a foreign learner's comprehension by providing the morphophonemically fullest forms of the target language," possibly providing helpful language cues to someone with lower English ability (Valdman, 1981).

Another interesting finding from the current study was that Chinese speakers felt less close to other people speaking their native language compared to Spanish speakers. This may suggest that Spanish-speaking participants exhibited a more pronounced in-group bias, feeling a greater sense of closeness to others who also speak Spanish. In a longitudinal study examining Spanish children's preferences, it was found that Spaniards significantly preferred their own group over others, allocating more positive adjectives towards their in-group (Enesco et al., 2011). On the other hand, when analyzing Chinese-speakers, numerous studies suggest that Asian-Americans experience a phenomenon called identity denial, in which they realize they are perceived as "less American than other Americans" and consequently claim greater participation in American practices, which could include rejecting people from their own native ethnicity (Cheryan & Monin, 2005; Wang et al., 2013).

Lastly, when examining correlations among characteristics related to receiving FT, it was found that the longer someone lived in the United States and the lower their self-reported accent, the less often they received FT. This outcome aligns with expectations, as both Chinese and Spanish speakers show cultural assimilation over the course of their stay in the United States. Previous research shows that the age at which someone learns a second language is a predictor for second-language accent (Moyer, 2018). Additionally, those who speak English with a non-native accent have been shown to receive stigma and discrimination in the United States, which could include receiving more FT (Sener, 2021). Participants in the current study who had lower English abilities actually found this use of FT as more helpful, suggesting that FT can also facilitate positive effects in aiding comprehension (Bobb et al., 2019).

As anticipated by Q3, participants with a higher self-reported accent showed less prejudice towards accents. One potential explanation for this finding is that people with accents tend to be more open-minded to how others speak, enabling them to understand language from another's point of view. Supporting this idea, a study evaluating attitudes towards others' foreign accents revealed that participants who grew up in an ethnically diverse environment, who had lived abroad and who were working in an ethnically diverse environment exhibited significantly more positive attitudes towards foreign accents (Dewaele & McCloskey, 2015).

**Implications of Findings**

The outcomes of this study can contribute to a deeper understanding of FT and highlight the sentiments of non-native speakers regarding interpersonal communication. Here we discuss two implications: the

impact of FT on non-native speakers, and potential consequences for native speakers employing FT.

Our data are consistent with Marlow's (2009) discussion of FT in terms of the receiver model of language criticism, suggesting that FT must be studied from the perspective of how it makes the non-native speaker feel. The model proposes that individual, contextual, and situational variables influence how people evaluate and respond to language criticism. Thus, it makes sense that some of the non-native speakers in the current study were adaptive and accommodating to receiving FT, while others may have experienced repressed anger, avoidance, or aggression (Marlow & Giles, 2010).

From the native-speaker's perspective, we hope that the findings of the current study can help speakers become cognizant of when they are using FT and whether their own preconceived notions are causing them to change their form of speech. One of the key findings of the CAT theory revealed that speakers accommodate not to where their recipients are in an objective sense, but rather where they are believed to be communicatively (Thakerar et al., 1982). Sometimes, speakers also change their speech to sound like the "prototype" of what they think a member of their recipient's in-group would sound like (Gallois & Callan, 1988). Through further education, as facilitated by the current study, native speakers can gain a deeper understanding that, despite positive intentions, their speech may inadvertently lead to miscommunication.

It is also important for all speakers to recognize that having an accent is not a hindrance, and foreign accents come with various social advantages. Over the years, research has demonstrated that non-native speakers are perceived as friendlier and more competent in the context of manual labor (Luhman, 1990; Giles et al., 1992). A recent study conducted in 2023 further revealed that speakers with accents were rated as more trustworthy and having more interpersonal appeal (Ip & Papafragou, 2023). Non-native speakers were partly protected against the social disadvantages associated with being "underinformative" compared to their native counterparts, indicating a phenomenon called social lenience towards non-native speakers (Ip & Papafragou, 2023).

**Limitations**

The study encountered a few limitations. For one, the sample size was notably small and the population of Chinese-speaking participants was below the goal determined by the power analysis. Consequently, generalizing results beyond the specific sample under investigation becomes challenging. Moreover, since the survey was conducted in English, individuals with limited English proficiency were unable to participate due to language barriers. This limitation could be addressed by offering the study in multiple languages to accommodate participants from diverse linguistic backgrounds. While the survey aimed for nationwide coverage, a significant portion of participants resided in Michigan, potentially impacting external validity. When collecting demographic data, the gender of participants was never asked, resulting in the inability to analyze and report gender-specific results. Lastly, the study was survey-based, leaving room for response bias and limited depth of exploring complex sentiments.

**Future Directions**

This study represents an initial step toward comprehending the use of FT, as well as the attitudes and perceptions of native speakers regarding FT. Moving forward, further research is imperative, particularly in regards to the use of FT with Chinese and Spanish speakers, given their significant populations in the United States. Subsequent investigations could involve experimental studies where participants receive FT from an actor, allowing for a direct assessment of their real-time reactions; this experimental approach offers the potential for analyzing responses in the moment, contrasting with reliance on self-reported measures obtained through surveys. A future focus on FT research holds the promise of eventually facilitating meaningful changes in the way we communicate with others.

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## Appendix A
### *Countries of origin*

| | |
|---|---|
| **Spanish speakers** | Colombia, Mexico, Argentina, Spain, Honduras, Chile, Ecuador, Uruguay, Dominican Republic, Puerto Rico, USA, Venezuela |
| **Chinese speakers** | Taiwan, China |

## Appendix B
### *Participants' Language Ideologies, Scaled Questions*

| Question | Ideology tested | Source |
|---|---|---|
| I think that speakers with accents should learn to speak English better | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents cannot speak English as well as native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents cannot express their opinions as well as native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents have more trouble interacting with others than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents cannot lead a group discussion as well as native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents are less informative than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents are less adapted to American culture than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents cannot be Americans. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Speakers with accents do not belong to America as much as native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| In America, it is best to speak English without a foreign accent. | Accent prejudice | Labtoka, 2018 |
| Speaking native sounding English will bring more respect than speaking with accents. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| An eyewitness with an accent is less trustworthy than an eyewitness who is a native English speaker. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Those speaking English with accents hold lower status than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Those speaking English with accents are less prestigious than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents are less intelligent than native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| It is harder to be friends with a person who speaks with an accent. | Accent prejudice | Labtoka, 2018 |
| When speakers get rid of their accent, they can be more successful in their career. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| I can work better with an accent-free coworker than a coworker with an accent. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| Speakers with accents should not attain as many management positions at native English speakers. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| I do not prefer to work under a boss with an accent. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| A professor with an accent is less effective than a professor with native English. | Accent prejudice | Ura et al., 2015 |
| The use of more than one language creates social problems. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| The use of more than one language makes social unity difficult. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| The use of more than one language makes social mobility difficult. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| Using one language to complete a task is better than using two languages. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| In the United States, knowing English helps a person to be American. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| Language represents national identity. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| The standard or model form of a language is the most appropriate form for school. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| In the United States, English is more normal than other languages. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| The use of language is a human right. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| Native languages are beautiful. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| In the United States, the use of native languages other than English is helpful for sharing tradition. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| Speakers have the right to choose the language they will use in any situation. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Labotka, 2018 |
| Schools must teach native languages of students. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| In the United States, the use of multiple languages is an economic asset. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| In the United States, the use of more than one language should be promoted. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| In the United States, public communication should occur in English. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| The success of a nation depends on the use of a national language. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2011 |
| English is the official language of the United States. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Labtoka, 2018 |
| It is patriotic to speak English in the United States. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Labtoka, 2018 |
| Immigrants to the United States should learn English. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Labtoka, 2018 |
| Immigrants to the United States should teach their children their native language. | Acceptance of monolingualism | Labtoka, 2018 |

**Appendix C**

***T-test: How do Spanish versus Chinese speakers evaluate FT, and who receives it more?***

| | **Spanish** | **English** | **t-Test** |
|---|---|---|---|
| | *M (SD)* | *M (SD)* | *t (df)* |
| **Receiving FT** | 1.61 (0.59) | 1.61 (0.50) | $t(61) = 0.007, p = .99$ |
| **Frequency of receiving FT** | 3.00 (1.39) | 2.83 (0.98) | $t(62) = 0.53, p = .60$ |
| **English ability** | 5.90 (1.00) | 5.05 (0.98) | $t(62) = 3.26, p = .002$* |
| **Attitudes toward receiving FT** | 3.18 (1.61) | 4.14 (1.21) | $t(62) = -2.48, p = .02$* |
| **Favor towards monolingualism** | 2.65 (0.61) | 2.94 (0.55) | $t(54) = -1.79, p = .08$ |
| **Prejudice against accents** | 1.82 (0.53) | 2.06 (0.64) | $t(54) = -1.52, p = .14$ |
| **Closeness to someone speaking native language** | 6.34 (0.88) | 5.43 (1.53) | $t(62) = 3.01, p = .004$* |
| **Closeness to someone speaking English** | 4.34 (1.68) | 4.48 (1.20) | $t(62) = -0.34, p = .73$ |
| **Closeness to someone after receiving FT** | 2.39 (1.71) | 2.43 (1.47) | $t(62) = -2.46, p = .02$* |
| **Feelings of belonging in the U.S.** | 4.07 (1.78) | 3.57 (1.72) | $t(62) = 1.11, p = .27$ |
| **Feelings of belonging after receiving FT** | 2.68 (1.94) | 2.78 (1.68) | $t(62) = -2.07, p = .84$ |

* T-test is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed)

**Appendix D**

***Correlations: What factors correlate to non-native speakers receiving FT?***

| | Positive attitudes toward FT | English ability | Accent in English | Age of English acquisition | Length of stay in the U.S. | Accent prejudice | Favor towards monolingualism |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Frequency of receiving FT | .22 | -.36* | .32* | -.11 | -.36* | .04 | .01 |
| Positive attitudes toward FT | | -.57* | .20 | .23 | .02 | .15 | .34* |
| English ability | | | -.24 | -.06 | .27 | -.10 | -.12 |
| Accent in English | | | | .41* | .03 | -.31* | -.07 |
| Age of English acquisition | | | | | .56* | -.29 | -.10 |
| Length of stay in the U.S. | | | | | | -.28 | -.09 |
| Accent prejudice | | | | | | | .53* |

* Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed)